

**THE CHAMPIONSHIP CUBE: A FRONT OFFICE FRAMEWORK FOR BUILDING NBA
CHAMPIONS**

Introduction

Modern roster construction requires frameworks that extend beyond traditional talent evaluation to address shifting competitive dynamics in the NBA. This study examines whether championship readiness can be evaluated as the alignment of statistical, organisational, and contextual dimensions. The Championship Cube contributes a mixed-method framework that combines measurable team, player, and coaching indicators with structured analysis of front-office, controllable-external, and uncontrollable-external factors. It applies this framework to NBA champions and their Finals opponents across the Physical, Transition, and Analytics Eras.

Methods

The study examines 74 team-season observations arranged into 37 champion–runner-up matched pairs spanning the 1989–90 through 2025–26 seasons, using data from Basketball-Reference. This matched-pair design compares champions with their Finals opponents, holding the competitive stage constant while examining differences in team and player strength. Logistic-regression models test SRS, Net Rating, and Defensive Rating individually and in combination; SRS is retained as the Team Face measure because Net Rating adds no independent signal in the combined specification. Player Face is measured using combined Top-3 Box Plus/Minus (BPM), while Coach Face is measured as actual regular-season wins minus Pythagorean expected wins. Beyond existing measures such as SRS, Net Rating, and BPM, the Cube integrates qualitative organisational dimensions. The Front Office, Controllable External, and Uncontrollable External Faces are evaluated through structured case-study analysis using a documented 0–2 rubric: absent or harmful, partial or mixed, or clearly aligned.

Results

Era	Champion DRtg	Runner-Up DRtg	Champion SRS	Runner-Up SRS
Physical	103.57	104.20	7.39	6.72
Transition	100.79	101.62	6.35	4.48
Analytics	106.81	108.96	7.25	4.60

Player Face provides the strongest standalone quantitative association in the tested specifications. The Player Face model was statistically significant ($p = 0.003$) and achieved 75.7% in-sample matched-pair classification accuracy, correctly classifying 28 of 37 pairs. SRS also distinguishes champions from Finals runners-up ($\beta = 0.33$, $p = 0.0035$, $n = 74$ team-season observations), achieving 67.6% in-sample matched-pair classification accuracy, correctly classifying 25 of 37 pairs. Statistical significance was assessed using pooled logistic regression, while classification performance was evaluated in-sample. SRS and combined Top-3 BPM are moderately correlated ($r = 0.61$), indicating overlapping but non-identical signals. Coach Face did not statistically distinguish champions from Finals runners-up in the final specification ($p \approx 0.62$). The SRS gap widened from 0.67 in the Physical Era to 2.65 in the Analytics Era.

Conclusion

Player Face and SRS provide the strongest quantitative associations in the sample, while regular-season coaching overperformance alone does not distinguish champions from Finals runners-up. The findings support the Cube as a structured diagnostic framework, not as a validated standalone prediction model. KIRIN operationalises this framework by identifying a team's weakest face, providing contextual Team Face analysis, reporting scenario uncertainty, and generating targeted recommendations. Because the sample is small, outcome-selected, and evaluated in-sample, future work must test the framework on broader team-season samples using out-of-sample validation.